JAPANESE INVASION OF KOREA

AFTER UNIFYING WAR-TORN JAPAN in 1590, warrior leader Toyotomi Hideyoshi then devised a megalomanic plan to conquer Ming China and India. When the Koreans refused to allow his army free passage through their country, in 1592 Hideyoshi embarked upon the conquest of Korea as a prelude to an invasion of China. Japanese troops were largely successful on land, advancing north as far as Pyongyang, but the Korean Admiral Yi Sunshin organized a naval campaign that severely disrupted Japan's supply lines. The Japanese suffered a crushing defeated at Hansando, but avoided total catastrophe in a defensive sea battle at Pusan. Hideyoshi was put under so much pressure, however, that he was forced to withdraw his troops in 1593. A second invasion in 1597 was no more successful. Although Japan scored a naval victory at Chilchonryang—in the absence of Yi Sunshin—the subsequent defeat at Myongyang was a setback from which Hideyoshi's project of conquest never recovered. The Japanese leader had died by the time Yi Sunshin inflicted the final humiliation on Japanese naval forces at Noryang in 1598, a battle that cost the Korean admiral his life.

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PUSAN



Date September 1,1592
Forces Koreans: c.250 ships; Japanese c.470 ships
Losses Unknown

Location
Pusan, Korea

In spring 1592 a vast Japanese fleet set off from Naguya on northern Kyushu island carrying an army some 160,000 strong for the invasion of Korea. The first 700 boats landed their troops near the fortified port of Pusan on April 13. The Koreans were caught unprepared. Their warships in the Pusan area, commanded by Won Kyun, simply fled when confronted by the Japanese armada. Toyotomi Hideyoshi's soldiers, battle-hardened after years of civil war in Japan, swiftly took Pusan by assault. As the Japanese fought their way up the Korean peninsula, Pusan became the gateway for supplies and reinforcements brought by sea from Japan.

Fortunately for Korea, Admiral Yi Sunshin, commander of the Cholla Left Naval District at Yosu, to the west of Pusan, was better prepared to react to the Japanese invasion. He had a force of cannon-armed warships, known as *panokseon*, and had recently completed construction of three iron-armored "turtle ships" or *kobukson*. With these ships he mounted a counterattack in the offshore islands between his base at Yosu and Pusan. In a five-day period in early May at and around Okpo, he sank 44 Japanese ships without loss. Further successes followed at Sachon, Tangpo, and Tanghangpo. When the Japanese attempted a major naval counterattack in August, they were shattered at the battle of Hansando.

After Hansando, Yi felt strong enough to attempt an attack on the Japanese base at Pusan. He was joined by the fleet of Won Kyun, creating a formidable force with more than 70 substantial warships. Pusan Bay was crowded with Japanese ships, which were landing a second wave of troops. Yi hoped to destroy the Japanese fleet and recapture or at least blockade Pusan. He was not successful. Although the Japanese lost many ships, they held off the attack using cannon captured from the Koreans. The Korean fleet was forced to withdraw but, with its supply lines insecure, the first Japanese invasion was doomed.



1545–1598

YI SUNSHIN

ADMIRAL OF THE KOREAN FLEET

Yi Sunshin pursued a successful career in the army until disgraced as a result of political machinations. In 1590, suddenly returned to favor, he was appointed naval commander of the Cholla District. His outstanding performance in a series of naval battles during the Japanese invasion of 1592 to 1593 did not save him from being once more disgraced and demoted to a lowly rank. Returned to command after the Korean defeat at Chilchonryang, he again trounced the Japanese at Myongyang and Noryang, dying in the hour of victory. Yi Sunshin is deservedly one of Korea's greatest national heroes.



Multiple rocket-launcher
The Koreans possessed an array of ingenious artillery weapons. These included the *hwacha*, a rocket-launcher used with great success both against Japanese land forces and for firing volleys of incendiaries at enemy ships.